

The Lanna Kingdom

Prosperity and
Decline
(1296–1558 A.D.)

An Educational Overview



A Chronology of the North



The Foundation (1296–1354 A.D.)

Key Figure: Phya Mangrai

Unified the northern regions and directed the strategic building of the New City (Chiang Mai) in 1296, establishing the physical and administrative center of the Lanna Kingdom.



Drivers of the Prosperous Period (1355–1525 A.D.)



Faith

Promoted Buddhism (specifically the Lanka sect). Initiated massive architectural projects to house sacred Buddha relics.



Force

Expanded territory across major river basins (Kok, Ping, Yom, and Nan). Secured control in Shan State and Laos by installing relatives as rulers over muangs and forming alliances via royal marriages.

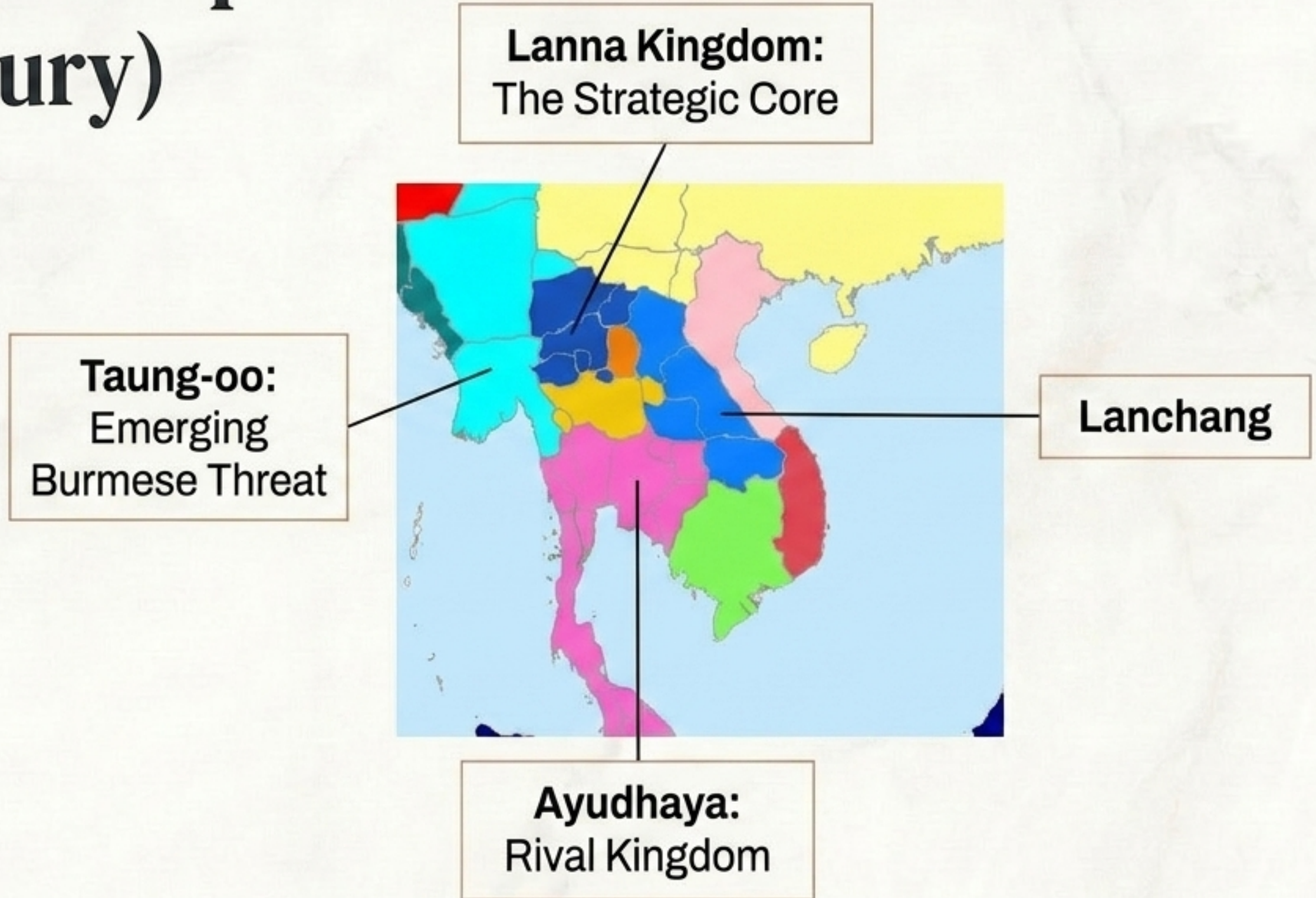


Trade

Established robust regional commerce driven by local resources, focusing on forest products, iron, handicrafts, and salt.

Geopolitical Landscape (15th–16th Century)

Lanna's central position enabled extensive trade and expansion, but left it geographically squeezed between formidable military powers (Sukhothai, Shan States, Ayudhaya, and Taung-oo).



Monuments of Faith: 14th Century



Name: Wat Suan Dok

Year: 1371 A.D.

Patron: King Kue Na



Name: Wat Phra That Doi Suthep

Year: 1383 A.D.

Patron: King Kue Na

The Great Temples: 15th Century



The Great Chedi Temple (Chedi Luang)

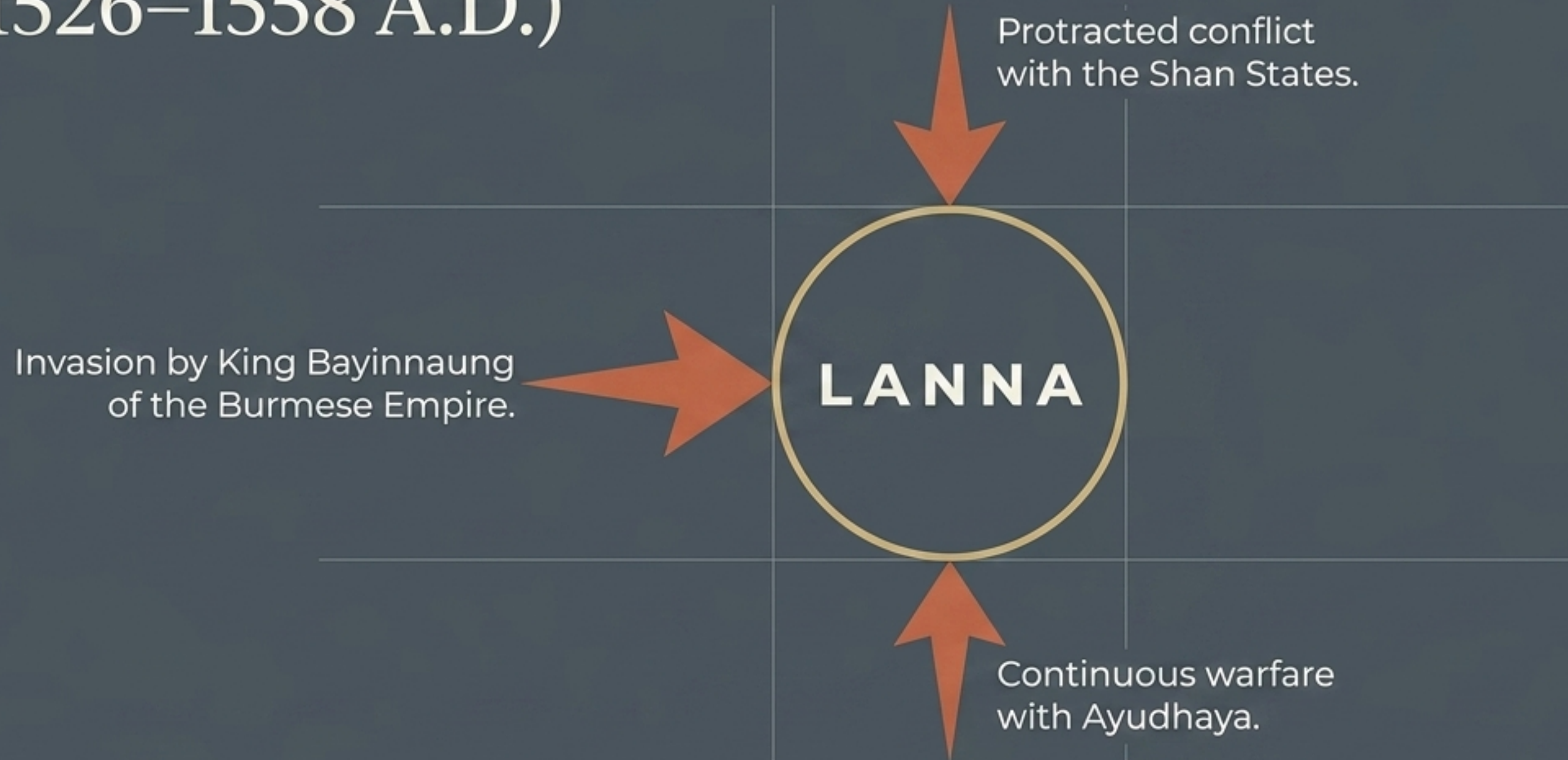
Constructed by King Saen; major developments during the 1450s under King Tilokaraj.

Wat Jed Yod

An ancient temple thoroughly renovated by King Tilokaraj in 1455 A.D., reflecting the zenith of Lanna's religious and economic prosperity.



The End of an Era (1526–1558 A.D.)



The Golden Age fractured under multi-front wars. By 1558, the Burmese Empire seized control of Lanna's most vital muangs, effectively ending its sovereignty.

Summary of the Lanna Kingdom

The Rise (1296–1354)	Unified by Phya Mangrai; centralized power with the construction of Chiang Mai.
The Peak (1355–1525)	Unprecedented prosperity driven by regional trade, strategic muang expansion, and massive architectural patronage under Kings Kue Na and Tilokaraj.
The Fall (1526–1558)	Exhausted by simultaneous conflicts with Ayudhaya and Shan States, ultimately falling to Burmese invasion.